Notes on *Notes from the Underground*[*]

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A tremendous amount of work has been devoted to examining Dostoevsky's life, philosophy, and writing, and in particular to *Notes from Underground*[1]. Here, I recall what I wrote in the preface about Tale 1 and then give some additional material.

1. Notes in Preface regarding Tale 1

Lens: Human Outlier Analysis (Foucault – "Madness and Civilization")

Our first story, *Notes from the Underground* by Fyodor Dostoevsky, takes place at a time I am pegging as the start of the "modern age." The story was first published in Russian in 1864 and takes place in Petersburg around 1862-1864, as the American Civil War is raging and as people in Russia are struggling with whether and how to absorb the lessons of the Western Enlightenment.

The unnamed protagonist of the story, often referred to as Dostoevsky's Underground Man, is in many ways an antihero. What he is defying seems to be the Enlightenment itself, and its concomitant notions of what is considered sane and acceptable. Many of us today might see the Underground Man as crazy in his verbose rambling and perverse actions. He may seem preposterous and confused, but do we lose something important if he is ostracized as a mental defective?

If we try to understand the Underground Man, perhaps we can better understand our fellow citizens today who seem to want to roll back to a time before Enlightenment values. Perhaps we can learn to recognize that they have important insights, even as we may view them as crazy.

One tool we will introduce could be called human outlier analysis[2].

[*]The title "Notes from the Underground" has also been translated as "Notes from Underground" and "Notes from a Mouse Hole".

[1]Here are links to series of lectures on the philosophy of *Notes from Underground*, by Gregory B. Sadler, "That Philosophy Guy":

- Notes From Underground | Existentialist Philosophy & Literature, YouTube 1:01:12
  - Here is a (computer generated) transcript of the above, divided into sections.
- Notes From Underground | Intellectuals Inertia and Negativity | Core Concepts, YouTube 17:26
- Notes From Underground | Pleasure, Perversity, and Suffering | Core Concepts, YouTube 16:06
- Notes From Underground | Revenge, Anger, and Justice | Core Concepts, YouTube 19:41
- Notes From Underground | Desire and Reason | Core Concepts, YouTube 17:59
- Notes From Underground | Self-Interest and the Advantageous | Core Concepts, YouTube 14:25
- Notes From Underground | The Most Advantageous Advantage | Core Concepts, YouTube 18:23
- Notes From Underground | Enlightenment, Laws of Nature, and The Will | Core Concepts, YouTube 16:14

[2]On human outlier analysis, see:

- *Madness and Civilization* by Michel Foucault, 1961.

  This posits that a phenomenon of the Age of Reason is the attempt to eliminate the irrational from philosophical discourse. Institutions (such as hospitals and prisons) were developed to outcast radical thinkers as mad or criminal.

We will ask questions about the Underground Man that could well be asked of ourselves and those around us:

- *How is the protagonist unusual in the society in which they live, and how are they trying to influence that society?*
- *Do you sympathize with the protagonist and his plight? What about the other characters?*
- *Can we usefully separate out the dysfunction from the creative insight?*
- *What does the protagonist see about society that those around him do not see?*

2. Additional Notes

In 1849, at the age of 28, Fyodor Dostoevsky had already published works that established his future as a great writer. He was arrested as a subversive for his active engagement in a discussion circle that talked of utopian ideas and was critical of the serfdom that was widespread in Russia. He was held without trial for months, before being subject to a mock execution, after which he was imprisoned in Siberia for four years, at hard labor under the supervision of guards who were frequently sadists. After that, he had six years of compulsory military service in exile in what is now Kazakhstan. He used these ten years to think deeply about society and human psychology. He came away from this experience with a deep spirituality, disdain for materialism, and appreciation of freedom, honesty, and integrity.[3]

His novella *Notes from the Underground*, published in 1864, "is considered one of the first works of existentialist literature.[4]" Existentialism is "a family of philosophical views and inquiry that explore the human individual's struggle to lead an authentic life despite the apparent absurdity or incomprehensibility of existence.[5]"

The novella[6] *Notes from the Underground* is essentially a long monologue by the protagonist and narrator, the "Underground Man". He is an intellectual who failed to thrive in society and has lived sparsely for many years. He calls himself a "mouse" and says he retreats to his "mouse-hole". He oscillates between bitterness at a society in which shallow people inferior to him thrive and loathing of himself for leading a pathetic existence.

Contained in the Underground Man's abstract intellectualized rambling in the first part of the story is a deep criticism of the selfish philosophy of "Rational egoism" (enlightened self-interest), which came out of Enlightenment thinking. He argues that this will never lead to utopian harmony. Although rationalism can provide many advantages, some people will always rebel at being denied "the most advantageous advantage", which is to have complete freedom to not be rational. In the novella, the symbol of what he is complaining about is the "The Crystal Palace" in contemporary writer Nikolai Chernyshevsky's novel *What Is to Be Done?*.

In *Notes from the Underground*, the Underground Man is trying to rebel against rationalism imposing 2+2=4 logic on him. Here is a relevant quote, from p. 8-9 of the Garnett translation, with boldface added:

> *When they prove to you that in reality one drop of your own fat must be dearer to you than a hundred thousand of your fellow creatures, and that this conclusion is the final solution of all so-called virtues and duties and all such prejudices and fancies, then you have just to accept it, there is no help for it, for twice two is a law of mathematics. Just try refuting it.*
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> *"Upon my word, they will shout at you,* ***it is no use protesting: it is a case of twice two makes four! Nature does not ask your permission*** *she has nothing to do with your*

[3] See Dostoevski Is Exiled to Siberia. [This is downloaded from here.]
[4] Quoted from the Wikipedia page on Fyodor Dostoevsky.
[5] Quoted from the Wikipedia page on Existentialism
[6] For the course we won't be reading the novella but rather watching one man show based on it, starring Larry Cedar. The lines in the show are a subset of the translation of *Notes from the Underground* by Constance Garnett.

wishes, and whether you like her laws or dislike them, you are bound to accept her as she is, and consequently all her conclusions. A wall, you see, is a wall. . .and so on, and so on."

In the production starring Larry Cedar, they had to edit out a lot of material, including the "twice to" lines. They keep the more visceral expression of the same concept, which is that the Underground Man is defiant to men being treated like "piano keys". This is captured in the following hand-edited transcript of the Cedar video, starting at 14:57. I have added paragraph breaks for readability, although the actual performance does not have so many pauses. The full, unedited transcript can be viewed on YouTube, or at the following link: YouTube transcript of the Cedar video.

... almost in the darkness, man everywhere at all times, whoever he may be, has preferred to act as he chose and not in the least as his reason an advantage dictated. And one may choose what is contrary to one's interests. And sometimes one positively ought.

What man wants is simply independent choice, whatever that independence may cost and wherever it may lead. Ladies and gentlemen, you must forgive me for being overly philosophical. It is the result of 40 years underground. Just allow me to indulge my fancy.

You see ladies and gentlemen, reason is an excellent thing. There is no disputing that. But reason is nothing but reason and satisfies only the rational side of man's nature. Will is a manifestation of the whole life that is the whole human life, including reason and all the impulses. And, although our life, in this manifestation of it, is often worthless – yet it is life and not simply, uh, extracting square roots.

I, for instance, quite naturally want to live in order to satisfy all my capacities for life, not simply my capacity for reasoning. That is not simply one twentieth of my capacity for life. What does reason know? Reason only knows what it has succeeded in learning. But human nature acts as a whole, with everything that is in it, consciously or unconsciously. And even if it goes wrong, it lives – hahaha.

Eh, I suspect ladies and gentlemen that you were looking upon me with compassion. You tell me again that an enlightened and developed man cannot consciously desire what is disadvantageous to himself. That this could be proven mathematically. Well, I thoroughly agree it can – by mathematics.

But, I repeat for the hundredth time, there is one case, one only, where man may consciously, purposely desire what is injurious to himself, what is stupid, very stupid, simply in order to have the right to desire for himself even what is very stupid and not be bound by an obligation to desire only what is sensible. For in any circumstances, it preserves for him what is most precious and most important: that is his individuality, his personality.

Oh, some you see maintain this really is the most precious thing for mankind. Choice can of course, if it chooses, be in agreement with reason. Especially if this be not abused and kept within bounds, it is profitable and sometimes even praiseworthy. But very often, even most often, choice is utterly and stubbornly opposed to reason. And, and, do you know that this too is profitable and sometimes even praiseworthy?

In short, one may say anything about the history of the world. The only thing one can't say is that it's "rational". The very word sticks in one's throat. And indeed, this is the odd thing that is continually happening. There are continually turning up in life moral and rational persons, hmm, sages and lovers of humanity who make it their object to live all their lives as morally and as rationally as possible, to be, so to speak, a light to their neighbors, simply in order to show them that it is possible to live morally and rationally in this world.

And yet, we all know those very persons sooner or later have been false to themselves, playing

> *some queer trick, often an unseemly one, simply in order to prove to themselves that men are still men and not the keys of a piano. And that is not all. Even if man really man were nothing but a piano key, even if this were proved to him by natural science and mathematics, even then he would not become reasonable but would purposely contrive some destruction, some chaos, purposely go mad in order to be rid of reason and gain his point. For the whole work of man really seems to consist in proving to himself, every minute, that he is a man and not a piano key.*
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> *Ladies and gentlemen, I am tormented by questions. Answer them for me. You for instance want to cure men of their old habits and reform their will in accordance with science and good sense. But how do you know, not only that it is possible, but also that it is desirable to reform man in that way. And what leads you to the conclusion that man's inclinations need reforming. In short, how do you know that such a reformation will be a benefit? …*

The Underground Man's plight is a prototype for that of many characters in Dostoyevsky's later works, namely that of characters trapped in an intellectualized cage, what I call the "cave of rational egoism". Dostoevsky's mock execution and imprisonment in Siberia helped him to come to the solution for him, namely that love and faith are the way out of the cave. In Crime and Punishment, which was written just after *Notes from the Underground* and published in 1866, the main character, Rodion Raskolnikov, responds to the dilemma of being powerless by killing an old woman for money that he believes will help him do great things. Like Dostoevsky himself, Raskolnikov is imprisoned in Siberia. There, he escapes from his cave of rational egoism through love and faith.

Raskolnikov and the Underground Man both react to the frustration of being an outsider unwilling to stay in the cave the society requires them to stay in, Raskolnikov escapes his cave, whereas the Underground Man stays trapped in his. This is made clear in the second part of (the show and the novella of) *Notes from the Underground*, which consists of flashbacks to stories of human interaction that the Underground Man had in the past. He stays trapped because his ego prevents him from accepting comradery or love.

As a pointer to where Dostoevsky was headed, I will end with the following summary of Chapter 3: Christian Themes in Crime and Punishment of the book Christian Fiction and Religious Realism in the Novels of Dostoevsky.

> *Only very gradually do religious themes start to play a role in Dostoevsky's literary work after his Siberian period. In spite of the fact that his detention in the Siberian penal colony greatly contributes to Dostoevsky's re-assessment of Christianity, Christian themes play no part in two of the first three works from the beginning of the 1860s, The* Insulted and Injured *and* Notes from the Underground. *Only at the end of the 60s do Christian themes and motifs become clearly defined in the psychological, ethical and ideological conflicts in the novels, finally culminating in the predominately religious novel,* The Brothers Karamazov.
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> *In* Notes from the Underground, *Dostoevsky did try to include a religious theme but, to his astonishment, the censor eliminated it. In a letter of March 26th, 1864, to his brother, Mikhail, Dostoevsky speaks with bitterness of the censor's activities in Chapter 10 of the first part: 'The censor pigs have passed everything where I scoffed at everything and, on the face of it, was sometimes even blasphemous, but have forbidden the parts where I demonstrated the need for belief in Christ from all this' (XVIII, 2, 73). This philosophical-psychological masterpiece has thus remained secular and Dostoevsky did not keep the missing part.*
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> *The themes from* Notes from the Underground, *however, not only the anti-rationalist and anti-utilitarian protests, but also the unfathomable depths of human freedom, have a direct relationship with Christian anthropology: the human will as a potential for good and evil.*